

Testimony of Commissioner Scott Dunn (Southwest Regional Hearing)

Redistricting

Fayette County PA has a unique set of demographics, population, geography, and industries that set us apart from other counties, even our close neighboring counties. As Commissioner of Fayette County, I see every day the needs of our communities and the demand for effective government to help address those needs.

The poverty rate in Fayette County is approximately 17.5%. This can be directly traced to the collapse of the coal and steel industries dating to the 1970's and the lack of leadership to fill that void. Job training has helped our citizens obtain new employment, but without the needed businesses in the County to support those jobs, that employment often times has been elsewhere. This has led to a precipitous population decline from over 200k in 1940 to 159k in 1980 to about 129k today.

Factoring into the population decline is lack of local college choices. While we have Penn State / Fayette and a number of vocational schools in County, our college bound students leave the County to pursue their post-secondary education. Many of these students do not return. Please note that the poverty rate for our educated and trained citizenry falls to 4.4%. As Commissioner, I see the need to add a community college type facility in County to help keep our students local and lower the poverty rate. Community colleges can also benefit by being in the high schools to keep those students on track to continue their education. The poverty rate for those who drop out of high school in Fayette County is 35%.

Much the same as other counties, Fayette struggles with the Opioid crisis and the related problems of crime, blight, behavioral health, healthy lifestyles, housing and food insecurity, among others. Much has been done to help alleviate these problems, but much work remains in the way of effectively addressing them.

Our industries have transformed over the years. Tourism and agriculture have become the #1 and #2 industries, in no particular order. The County has a robust health care system with two local hospitals, WVU Medicine/Uniontown Hospital and Highlands Hospital in Connellsville. I believe as a County leader that this industry is primed to take off in the near future. It is needed for other industries to expand, including manufacturing, education, and the trades.

Fayette County has great amenities to promote. A UNESCO World Heritage Site, Fallingwater, is located within our borders. We have a 5-star resort at Nemacolin Woodlands. Also located here is one of the biggest state parks, Ohiopyle, that offers outdoor recreation like to other in the state. The County is seeing in excess of 1.5 million visitors annually.

Good things are happening in Fayette County. I believe we have strong, committed leadership at each level of government. It is important that any new district that includes Fayette County represent the citizens and needs of the County. This is difficult to do if a district is too widespread. In the past, our Congressional district included parts in the center of the State. These areas often have little in common with the needs of Fayette County.

I strongly recommend creating districts that have counties and communities with similar needs and demographics so that these problems can be effectively addressed by our government.

Thank you for allowing my time to offer these thoughts and ideas.

Scott Dunn

Fayette County Commissioner